

CHAPTER 2 — THE COST OF THE FLAME

The search for the Night Stalker finally ended in the southern reaches of Velldénar, at a secluded hut hidden deep within the Dark Forest. Nathanos Thornwell and his squad had followed the trail through blood and snow, but the battle had nearly been lost. When hope seemed to be fading, Raphael Marchand seized the only chance they had: he caught the Night Stalker from behind and held her in place, giving Nathanos the opening to strike.

Nathanos drove his heated blade through the Night Stalker's chest, killing her—but the same blow pierced Raphael and left him gravely wounded. As the mask fell, Nathanos saw the impossible: the Night Stalker was a woman with a face identical to his own. Her final words broke apart unfinished, and the living bandages from her back fell lifeless into the snow.

For a moment, the sight shook Nathanos to his core, but Raphael was bleeding out before him. Whatever horror the face had awakened, he forced it down and turned back to the living. Using his inner flame, he sealed Raphael's wound long enough to move. Raphael reminded him that the hunt was over, their fallen had not died for nothing, and Kalluth would need proof. Nathanos took the bone-white mask, fastened it to his belt, and carried Raphael away from the clearing—leaving the dead behind until they could return.

Snow drifted down from a pale, colorless sky.

High above the forest floor, beneath the shelter of black pine needles, a small bird bent over its nest and pushed the last torn piece of food into the open mouths of its young. The hatchlings stirred blindly, fragile throats stretching, thin cries rising into the cold as they begged for more.

The mother bird lifted her head.

Below, between the trees, something moved.

Two figures emerged slowly from the white. One walked. One was carried more than guided, his arm hooked over the other's shoulder, his feet dragging through the snow in uneven lines. They passed beneath the branches like things half-returned from a grave, leaving a dark trail behind them that the falling snow tried, and failed, to hide.

The hatchlings cried again, hungry and unaware.

The mother bird watched a moment longer, black eyes fixed on the wounded shapes below. The forest around them remained still, but not peaceful. The kind of stillness that listened. The kind that waited.

Then her wings snapped open, scattering a dusting of snow from the branch, and she vanished into the grey.

Raphael made a low sound with the next step.

Not a word. Not even close. Only pain, dragged through clenched teeth as his weight sagged harder against Nathanos's side. His eyes had been closed for most of the way, lashes dusted with melting snow, his face pale beneath the blood and cold. Each breath came unevenly, caught somewhere deep in his chest, and every few steps a faint red stain touched the corner of his mouth before he swallowed it down.

Nathanos saw it.

Of course he saw it.

He had seen every change in Raphael since they left the clearing. Every weakening step. Every tremor in his knees. Every breath that came too shallow, too wet, too carefully held. He had been watching him with the same sharpness he used on the trees, the snow, the shadows between the trunks.

Because the Night Stalker was dead, but that did not mean Velldengar was safe.

The Nightmares were still out there somewhere. Perhaps not near. Perhaps not hunting them. Perhaps only distant shapes in the deep woods, hiding from the cold light of day. But this was their land as much as anyone's, and Nathanos knew better than to trust silence simply because the thing they had come to kill now lay dead behind them.

Death did not always make a forest harmless.

So he listened.

For claws beneath snow. For breathing that was not theirs. For the wrong kind of silence. For the thin, awful scrape of something following.

And still, even through all of that, his attention kept snapping back to Raphael. To the blood at his mouth. To the wound beneath his armor. To the fear Nathanos had been trying not to name since the blade came free.

The wound was not only flesh. It had never been only flesh. He had known it the moment Raphael's blood kept coming despite the flame, the moment the seal gave way once, then again. Something deeper had been torn. Something inside him had taken the blade too.

"Raphael," Nathanos said, breathless from the effort of keeping them both moving. His voice stayed low, but urgency sharpened every syllable. "Are you still with me?"

Raphael's head shifted against his shoulder.

For a second, that was all.

Then he gave a small, painful nod.

"Still here," he rasped.

The words were thin, almost swallowed by the snow, but they were words, and Nathanos held on to them like a command.

“Good,” he said. “Stay that way.”

They pushed forward, step by careful step, through the trees and falling snow. Nathanos bore most of Raphael’s weight now, one arm locked around his back, the other ready to catch him if his legs failed completely. His own body ached from cold and shock, but he did not slow. He could not. Not while Raphael’s breath kept hitching. Not while blood still darkened his lips. Not while every shadow in the forest looked as if it might unfold into teeth.

A branch cracked somewhere to their left.

Nathanos stopped at once.

Raphael stirred weakly against him, but Nathanos tightened his hold, silent, listening. His blue eyes cut through the trees, searching the white gloom. Snow fell in soft sheets between the trunks. Nothing moved. Nothing breathed where it should not.

Only the forest.

Only the cold.

Only their own ragged breathing.

After a moment, Nathanos forced them onward.

Raphael's mouth twitched faintly, though his eyes stayed closed. "Jumping at birds now?"

"Save your breath."

"That was almost an answer."

"It was a warning."

Raphael gave the ghost of a laugh, but it broke into a strained inhale. His fingers clenched in Nathanos's coat, and for a moment his weight dipped so suddenly that Nathanos nearly stumbled with him.

"Raphael."

"I know," Raphael breathed. "Still here."

"You keep saying that like it is enough."

"It is working so far."

Nathanos wanted to snap at him. Wanted to tell him that humor would not keep his insides from bleeding, that pride would not carry him back to Kalluth, that if he collapsed here beneath the trees, Nathanos did not know if he could save him a third time.

But then, through the pines, the carrier came into view.

Dark wood. Iron fittings. The crest of Kalluth half-hidden beneath frost. Around it, the horses waited where they had been left, restless beneath the branches, their breath rising in white clouds. The other mounts stood nearby without riders, shifting uneasily in the snow, ears twitching toward the forest as if they too felt something wrong lingering between the trees.

“We’re there,” Nathanos said quickly. “Do you hear me? Just a few more steps.”

Raphael’s eyes opened only briefly, red and glassy beneath heavy lids, just long enough to see the carrier waiting between the trees.

A faint smile touched his mouth.

“Never doubted you,” he breathed.

The next step nearly broke that lie.

Pain flared through him so violently that his fingers dug into Nathanos's coat. The wound, the movement, the heat Nathanos had forced into it again and again to keep him alive—it all burned together until Raphael could no longer tell where one agony ended and the next began.

So he thought of fire.

Not this pain. Not the wound. Not the blood in his mouth.

Fire.

The Searing Flame.

It was madness, really, that Nathanos could command it. Raphael had known the stories all his life. Everyone in Kalluth knew them. The holy flame had burned in the city since the first day of its founding, a gift given by the Matriarch of the Rannaketh, sacred, meant to hold back the darkest creatures that crawled from the depths of Velldengar.

For generations, it had been protection. A symbol. A warning to anything born from shadow that Kalluth would not kneel.

But no one had been known to truly wield it.

Not until High Exarch Alexandre.

And Nathanos.

Alexandre, leader of the Searing Flame and the right hand of Aren Thornwell, could call that holy fire into his hands as if prayer itself had taken shape. He could turn it into judgment, into punishment, into something that made even monsters remember fear.

And Nathanos carried it too.

The crown prince. The cursed prince, some still whispered when they thought no loyal ears were near.

But Raphael had felt that flame with his own body now. Not as judgment. Not as destruction. As warmth pressed into torn flesh. As holy fire forced into gentleness, holding him together when he should have been bleeding out into the snow.

Raphael opened his eyes a fraction and looked at him.

Nathanos's face was fixed forward, pale and severe, blue eyes locked on the carrier as if will alone could drag them there faster. Snow clung to his blond hair, to his lashes, to the dark lines of his coat.

He looked nothing like a prince.

He looked exhausted.

Terrified.

Alive.

Raphael's thoughts slipped, fevered and unsteady, back to the older stories. To the Day of Madness. To Eneth Thornwell, his idol, and the companions who had drawn the Lord of Dread from shadow with that same sacred flame and faced him when the world had begun to break.

The same fire.

The same bloodline.

The same impossible burden.

There was a pattern there, Raphael thought dimly. Or maybe pain was making him see one. Fire answering dread. Thornwells walking into darkness because the rest of the world needed someone to do it first.

And now Nathanos had walked into that same darkness.

But not alone.

Raphael had held the Night Stalker in place. He had crushed her against him with everything he had left, even when the bandages writhed and the claws searched for skin, even when he knew the blade would have to pass through him too. Without that hold, without that one brutal opening, Nathanos would never have reached her heart.

Together, they had brought her down.

The terror of the southern region. The creature tied again and again to the Lord of Dread. A shadow from the same old horror, ended beneath Thornwell flame and Marchand blood.

The thought almost became something larger, something Raphael's pain-clouded mind tried to follow.

But before he could, Nathanos shifted beneath him and tightened his hold.

"We're here," Nathanos said.

The carrier stood before them now, close enough to touch.

Raphael let out a breath that trembled into something almost like a laugh. Relief softened his face for half a heartbeat, gentle despite the pain.

“Good,” he whispered. “I was starting to think you were taking the scenic route.”

Nathanos shot him a look, sharp with worry and exhaustion both.

Raphael’s faint smile remained, but his eyes closed again almost at once.

Nathanos did not waste another word. He guided him the last few steps toward the carrier, still listening to the trees, still watching the snow, still waiting for the forest to send one final horror after them.

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The carrier door opened with a hard groan of wood and iron.

Cold wind rushed in at once, sharp enough to steal the breath from the small space inside. Snow followed with it, scattering in pale flecks across the dark floorboards, across the benches, across Nathanos's coat as he hauled Raphael in with him.

Raphael barely helped. His arm hung heavy over Nathanos's shoulder, his boots dragging against the step before they found the floor. Every breath left him rough and uneven, as if his body had forgotten how to take in air without fighting for it first.

“Easy,” Nathanos murmured.

This time, the word was not command. It was care trying not to become panic.

He pulled the door mostly shut behind them with one hand, leaving only a narrow crack of winter light at the edge, then steadied Raphael before he could sink too low.

For a moment, Nathanos's eyes moved through the carrier.

Dark polished wood. Iron fittings. Two cushioned benches faced each other, one along each side, wide enough to carry four people in comfort if the road was kind and the passengers had not come from slaughter. Pillows rested at either end, stitched in deep royal colors now dulled by the grey light. A small window sat on each side, frost gathering at the corners of the glass, with another set into the door behind them.

Above, four candle holders were fixed into the ceiling frame, unlit for now, their blackened wicks waiting for night. Along the upper compartments and beneath the seats sat the supplies meant for longer roads: wrapped food, water flasks, folded cloths, spare utensils, a small knife, a fork, and other simple things that suddenly felt too ordinary for blood and winter.

A royal carrier.

Made for distance. For comfort. For ceremony, even.

Not this.

Nathanos guided Raphael toward the nearest bench, slow and careful, taking most of his weight as the soldier's knees threatened to give beneath him. He lowered him down at the far corner, turning him just enough that his shoulder plate rested against the wooden side and the softened back of the bench.

Raphael sank into it with a strained breath, head tipping back, eyes half-lidded.

For a moment, Nathanos only watched him. Raphael's chest rose too fast, fell too hard, then rose again. His whole body seemed to be fighting the wound now, every breath, every tremor, every flicker of pain across his face part of the same desperate effort to stay alive. The bleeding had slowed, but not enough to make Nathanos trust it. Not enough to make him breathe easier.

Raphael's lips parted slightly, dry and pale.

Nathanos looked up at the dark ceiling frame, where the four candle holders waited with blackened wicks. The carrier was too dim. Too cold.

He raised his hand and set two fingers carefully around the first candle's wax stem. A breath of inner flame answered him, small and golden, slipping from his fingertips without heat enough to harm the wood. The wick caught softly.

Then the second.

The third.

The fourth.

One by one, the candles stirred to life, their flames trembling with the movement of the carrier and the wind still pressing at the door. Warm light spread across the polished wood, over Raphael's pale face, over the blood-darkened armor, over Nathanos's hands as he lowered them again.

Only then did Nathanos turn to the storage compartment.

He opened it with a sharp pull and searched until his fingers closed around a folded cloth, a glass, a knife, and a water flask. The glass knocked softly against the wood as he brought it down, his own hands less steady than he wanted them to be.

Before pouring, he crouched before Raphael and leaned closer.

A thin line of blood still marked the corner of Raphael's mouth, left from the slow, painful walk to the carrier. It had dried there in a dark smear against skin gone too pale.

Nathanos folded the cloth once around his fingers and wiped it away carefully.

Raphael's eyes opened a fraction, unfocused at first, then settling on him.

"It's only blood," Raphael whispered, as if trying to make it smaller than it was.

"I know," Nathanos said softly.

But he wiped until it was gone.

Only then did he reach for the flask.

He poured carefully.

Water caught the candlelight, clear and trembling.

Then he lifted the glass.

“Drink,” Nathanos said.

Raphael’s eyes opened a little more. The familiar defiance tried to return, but it barely reached his mouth.

“I can—”

“No.” Nathanos’s voice softened before the word could turn too sharp. He steadied Raphael with one hand, careful not to let him shift forward. “Don’t. Please. The wound has opened once already. If it tears again...”

He stopped himself.

Raphael's eyes moved to him, heavy with pain but still aware.

Nathanos swallowed, then lifted the glass a little closer.

“Let me do this,” he said quietly. “Just this once.”

For a moment, the old smile tried to return to Raphael's mouth.

“You make it sound like I have a choice.”

Nathanos's face softened despite himself.

“You don't.”

Raphael gave the smallest nod.

Nathanos lifted the glass to his lips with care, one hand supporting the back of Raphael's head so the movement would not pull at the wound. He tilted the glass slowly, letting only a little water pass at first.

Raphael swallowed with visible effort.

Some of it spilled at the corner of his mouth and ran down toward his jaw. Nathanos caught it with his thumb before it could reach the collar of his armor, then tipped the glass again.

“Slowly,” he murmured. “Not too much.”

Raphael obeyed this time. He drank in small, painful swallows, eyes closed, breath shaking between each one. Nathanos kept the glass steady at his lips, patient and tense, watching every movement as if even water could become dangerous if given too quickly.

When Raphael turned his face away at last, Nathanos lowered the glass.

“Enough?”

Raphael swallowed once more, then gave a faint nod.

“For now,” he whispered, his eyes barely open. “Thank you, Nathanos.”

Nathanos set the glass aside, close enough to reach again, then looked back at the wound.

Raphael’s head rested against the wooden side, his breathing still too fast, too shallow, though some color had returned to his mouth after the water. The candlelight moved over him in soft, unsteady gold, catching on the edges of his armor, on the blood that had dried dark between plates, on the place where Nathanos’s blade had passed through him.

Nathanos's gaze settled there.

The wound was hidden beneath steel, leather, cloth, and all the desperate work his flame had done in the snow. From outside, he could see only what the armor allowed him to see: torn fabric, scorched edges, blood, and the place where heat had sealed what should not have been survivable.

It was not enough.

He needed to know what lay beneath.

Raphael noticed the silence. His eyes opened a little.

“That look usually means pain.”

Nathanos did not deny it.

“I need to remove the armor.”

Raphael's mouth tightened.

Nathanos leaned closer, voice low, careful. “I have to see the wound properly. Not through steel. Not through torn cloth. Flesh. Skin. All of it.” His eyes flicked toward the storage compartments. “There is water here, bandages, blankets. Spare clothes as well. I’ll clean what I can, check if the wound has opened again, and get you out of this armor before the weight worsens anything.”

Raphael stared at him for a moment, fever-bright eyes trying to focus.

“And during this?” he asked.

“You do not move unless I tell you to.” Nathanos’s voice softened before it could become an order. “Not because I think you are weak. Because if that wound tears again, Raphael...”

He stopped.

The unfinished sentence hung between them.

Raphael understood it anyway.

A faint breath left him, almost a laugh, but too thin to carry any humor. “I always imagined being undressed by someone with a little less royal authority.”

Despite himself, Nathanos’s mouth almost moved.

Almost.

“This is not the time.”

“No,” Raphael whispered. “I know.”

Still, the awkwardness remained in his face, shy and uneasy beneath the pain. It was not only that Nathanos was undressing him. It was that Nathanos was a man, and more than that, a Thornwell—the same bloodline as the hero Raphael had admired all his life.

That made it worse somehow.

This was something else entirely. Something too intimate for rank. Too helpless for pride.

Still, he gave the smallest nod.

“Do it.”

Nathanos moved carefully.

He started with the shoulder plates.

His fingers found the first fastening near Raphael's collar, working the strap loose with slow precision. The leather had stiffened from cold and blood, and for a moment it resisted him. Nathanos did not pull harder. He adjusted his grip, eased the buckle free, then supported the weight of the plate before it could drag against Raphael's body.

"Gentle," Raphael breathed.

"I know," Nathanos said softly. "I have you."

The first shoulder plate came away with a dull shift of metal.

Raphael inhaled sharply, not in pain this time, but relief. His body sank deeper into the bench as if some invisible hand had stopped pressing him down.

Nathanos set the plate on the floorboards beside him, then removed the second.

That one came free easier. Without the heavy iron at his shoulders, Raphael looked smaller, more human beneath the armor. Less commander. Less heir of Marchand. More like the wounded man Nathanos had dragged out of the snow by sheer refusal to let him die.

The red cloak came next.

Nathanos loosened it carefully from around Raphael's shoulders, lifting the dark, blood-dampened fabric away from him inch by inch. The golden medallion fastened to its right side caught the candlelight as it moved—the sigil of the Searing Flame carved into its face, bright even beneath smears of snow and blood.

For a moment, Nathanos's hand paused on it.

Then he placed the cloak on the floor beside the shoulder plates, the medallion resting against the red cloth like a small, silent sun.

Raphael watched him through half-lidded eyes.

There was no jest this time. Only trust, and pain, and the quiet humiliation of needing help with something his own hands could no longer do.

Then Nathanos turned to the chest plate.

The armor was held by four main fastenings: two belts crossing high near the shoulders, and two fixed at the sides beneath the arms. All of them were dark with blood and damp from melted snow. Nathanos began at the top, undoing the first shoulder belt with slow, careful fingers.

Raphael made a low sound through his teeth.

Nathanos looked at him at once.

Raphael shook his head faintly. “Keep going.”

So Nathanos did.

The second shoulder belt gave after a moment. Then the side fastening. Then the other. Each buckle loosened with a soft scrape of leather and metal, and with each one Raphael’s breathing grew thinner, more uneven, his fingers curling and uncurling against the bench as if he were trying to hold himself still by force alone.

Neither of them spoke.

At last, the chest plate was free enough to lift.

Nathanos placed one hand beneath the lower edge and the other against Raphael’s side to steady him. He did not trust the armor. Not the blood. Not the scorched cloth beneath it. Not the silence between one breath and the next.

“Slowly,” Raphael whispered.

“Yes.”

Nathanos lifted.

Only a little.

At once, he felt it.

A pull.

Not from a buckle. Not from caught leather.

From beneath.

Something resisted the movement of the armor with a sickening, living tension, as if the plate had grown roots into the wound itself.

Raphael screamed.

The sound filled the carrier, sharp and raw, tearing out of him before either of them could stop it. His head struck back against the wooden side, his body arching despite every effort to stay still. His hands clawed at the bench, nails scraping hard over the fabric, dragging desperate lines through it while tears spilled down his face.

Outside, wings exploded from the nearby trees. A flock of small birds burst into the grey air, startled from the branches by the scream, scattering through falling snow.

Nathanos froze instantly.

The chest plate remained in his hands, held exactly where it was. Fresh blood welled from beneath the lower edge and ran over his fingers, warm against his skin.

Raphael's scream broke into a choking gasp.

“Stop,” he begged. “Stop—”

“I stopped.” Nathanos's voice came out strained, but he did not move.

“It feels—” Raphael sucked in a broken breath, tears still slipping down toward his jaw. “It feels like you're ripping my skin off.”

The words struck colder than the wind outside.

Nathanos stared down at the place where armor, cloth, blood, and sealed flesh disappeared into one another beneath the plate.

The candlelight flickered.

His stomach turned.

No.

No, no.

His flame.

The heat he had forced into the wound. The desperate sealing. The scorched edges of cloth and leather. The metal pressed tight against Raphael's stomach while Nathanos had burned the bleeding shut.

For one terrible moment, Nathanos understood.

He had not only sealed flesh.

He may have burned it to the armor.

"No," Nathanos whispered.

His face went pale beneath the candlelight, horror opening slowly across it.

"No, this can't be..."

Raphael looked at him, breathing hard through clenched teeth. Pain had already sharpened his expression, but fear entered it now—quiet, knowing fear. He had felt the pull. He had felt what Nathanos had only just understood.

“It happened when you sealed it,” Raphael said, voice thin.

Nathanos could not answer.

The flame had saved him.

The flame had trapped him.

Raphael swallowed, fighting to stay conscious through the pain. “You couldn’t have known.”

“I should have.”

“No.” Raphael’s fingers trembled against the torn bench fabric. “You have never done it like this before. Not through armor. Not through cloth. Not with me bleeding out in the snow.”

Nathanos lowered the plate only enough to ease the pull, careful not to press it back into the wound. His hand remained beneath the edge, bloodied fingers holding the armor in place because he no longer trusted what would happen if he let it settle.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Outside, the birds were gone.

Only the wind remained.

Raphael's breathing shook in the silence.

"If it stays like this," he whispered, "it will kill me."

Nathanos looked at him.

Raphael's face was wet with tears, pale with pain, but his eyes stayed open. Afraid, yes.

Exhausted. But still fixed on Nathanos.

"The wound will rot beneath it," Raphael said. "The road will pull at it. Every movement. Every turn. If the metal has sealed into me..." His voice faltered. "Then we already know the answer."

Nathanos's jaw tightened.

"I may have another way."

Raphael closed his eyes for a moment. "I hate that sentence."

"I can heat the armor."

Raphael opened his eyes again.

Nathanos spoke quickly, before fear could twist the words worse than they already were. “The flame itself will not burn you. I can control that much. But the metal will take the heat. If I soften what has sealed against it, I may be able to loosen the plate instead of tearing it free.”

Raphael stared at him.

“And if it does not loosen?”

Nathanos did not lie.

“Then part of the skin may still come with it.”

Raphael’s lips parted.

For a moment, he looked away.

Not in anger. Not in doubt. Only because the thought was too much to hold while looking at the man who would have to do it.

Nathanos’s voice lowered. “Raphael...”

“I know.”

“You do not have to answer at once.”

“Yes,” Raphael whispered. “I do.”

Nathanos shook his head faintly.

Raphael looked back at him, and there was fear in him now without disguise. “If this stays, I die slower. If you try, I might survive.” His breath hitched. “I do not like those choices.”

“Neither do I.”

“But there they are.”

The carrier creaked around them. Nathanos still held the armor with one bloodied hand.

Raphael swallowed hard, then gave the smallest nod.

“Do it.”

Nathanos's eyes tightened with pain.

Raphael saw it and tried, weakly, to steady him. "You are not doing this to me, Nathanos. You are doing it for me."

The words nearly broke something in him.

Nathanos looked down for a moment, breathing once through his nose, forcing the fear back into his hands where it could become control.

Then he reached beneath the bench with his clean hand and pulled out one of the folded towels stored there for travel. He shook it open, folded it twice, then once more, making it thick enough to bite but soft enough not to hurt Raphael's jaw.

Raphael watched the movement.

His eyes changed.

He understood before Nathanos said it.

"No," Raphael breathed.

“I need you to bite down on this.”

Raphael’s gaze flicked toward the door, toward the dark world beyond it. “Because of the scream.”

“And because of your teeth.” Nathanos brought the folded towel closer, but did not force it. “If the pain comes hard, you will need something between them.”

Raphael’s breathing turned shallow.

For the first time since Nathanos had dragged him into the carrier, he looked truly young beneath all the blood and command and noble pride. Afraid not of battle, not of death in the clean heroic shape songs liked to give it, but of pain. Of the next breath. Of what would happen when Nathanos touched fire to metal and the armor answered.

Nathanos leaned closer.

“I will be as careful as I can.”

“I know.”

“I will stop if I must.”

Raphael gave a faint, bitter shake of his head. “No. If you stop every time I want you to, we will never finish.”

Nathanos said nothing.

Raphael’s eyes shone in the candlelight. “Just... stay with me.”

Nathanos’s expression softened.

“I am not leaving you.”

The words settled between them, quiet and absolute.

Raphael opened his mouth.

Nathanos placed the folded towel between his teeth with care, adjusting it so he could bite down without choking. Raphael’s jaw closed around it, trembling almost at once.

Nathanos set his bloodied hand more firmly beneath the chest plate. His clean hand hovered over the metal.

Gold light began to gather beneath his fingers, soft at first, no brighter than candleflame.

Raphael’s eyes stayed on him. Nathanos looked back.

Both of them were afraid.

Neither of them looked away.

Nathanos let the flame deepen.

Not all at once. Not recklessly. He fed it into the metal in slow, controlled breaths, golden light spreading beneath his fingers until the chest plate began to drink it in. The first warmth moved through the armor like dawn through iron, faint enough that Raphael only stiffened, his jaw tightening around the folded towel. Then Nathanos pushed more of himself into it.

The metal answered.

Raphael's eyes widened.

Heat reached him through the plate, not from the flame itself, but from the armor Nathanos had turned into a vessel for it. His body strained against the bench, every muscle locking as pain climbed through him. A muffled sound broke against the towel in his mouth, low at first, then sharper, strangled behind cloth as his teeth sank down hard.

Nathanos did not look away.

“I know,” he whispered, though Raphael could not answer. “I know. Hold on.”

The armor grew hotter.

A thin hiss rose from beneath the plate: blood, sealed flesh, trapped cloth. The sound was small, almost delicate, and more terrible for it. A wet, burning whisper filled the carrier, followed by the sharp scent of scorched blood and heated metal. It curled into the candlelit air, thick and bitter, until even the cold wind pressing at the door could not hide it.

Raphael shook beneath him. His hands clawed at the bench again, nails dragging through fabric, his shoulders pressed hard into the wood as the pain tore through him in waves. Tears ran freely now, down his temples, along his jaw, into the sweat gathering at his throat. Every breath came broken through his nose. Every scream died half-smothered against the towel.

Nathanos felt the pull change.

Not gone. Never gone. But weaker.

The place where flesh and cloth had clung to the armor began to loosen beneath the heat. A sickening softness entered the resistance, as if the wound itself had started to give way.

Now.

They both knew it.

Raphael's eyes found his, wet and wild with pain.

Nathanos tightened his grip.

“Forgive me.”

Then he tore the chest plate free in one hard motion.

Raphael's scream crushed itself into the towel as his whole body arched from the bench. The armor came away with a wet, ripping sound, cloth tearing with it, scorched fabric and blood-darkened pieces of flesh clinging to the inner side of the plate. Fresh blood surged beneath, hot over Nathanos's hand, but the wound did not open fully. The flame's earlier sealing held just enough to keep Raphael from spilling apart beneath him.

The plate burned against Nathanos's palm. Even controlled, even born from him, the heat of the metal was too much.

He threw it aside.

It struck the floorboards with a heavy clang, smoking faintly where torn cloth still clung to it.

Raphael sagged back against the bench, trembling so violently the cushions shifted beneath him. His eyes were open, but unfocused. His face had gone white except for the flushed fever of pain across his cheeks. Sweat covered his chest, his throat, his brow. The towel remained clenched between his teeth, soaked where his breath had passed through it.

Nathanos had no time to comfort him. Not yet.

He bent over the wound at once.

Small fragments remained where the armor had refused to leave cleanly: tiny dark points of metal, burned cloth, pieces caught near the sealed edge of flesh. Nathanos brought the flame back smaller this time, narrower, no larger than a thread of gold between his fingers. He touched it to the fragments, burning the cloth away, loosening the metal from the wound without letting the fire bite deeper than he commanded.

Raphael's body jerked with every touch. The sounds he made were no longer screams, not fully. They were broken, muffled sobs of pain that shook through his chest and died against the towel. His hands had stopped clawing now. They only trembled, fingers curled uselessly against the ruined bench, as if even gripping had become too much.

"I'm almost done," Nathanos said, voice rough. "Raphael, stay with me. Almost done."

He pushed one loosened piece free with the side of his finger.

Then another.

A blackened thread of cloth came away next, stuck wetly to his skin before he cast it aside. He worked with terrible care, every motion small and exact, every breath held until the wound was finally free of metal, free of cloth, free of the thing his own flame had accidentally made.

Only then did Nathanos reach for the knife.

He cut through what remained of Raphael's ruined gambeson and undershirt, slicing the fabric open from the torn edge upward, then pulling it away from his chest and shoulders. The cloth came off in stiff, bloodied pieces. Beneath it, Raphael's body looked stripped of all the command he usually carried: bare skin, sweat, bruises, blood, and the terrible wound across his stomach where flame had sealed what steel had destroyed.

Nathanos stared at it.

For one breath, he could not help himself.

The wound was closed, but not healed. Not truly. The flesh was scorched at the edges, uneven and angry, marked by the path of the blade and by Nathanos's desperate fire. It would never vanish. Even if Raphael survived, even if he walked again, fought again, laughed again, this would remain.

A scar for life.

But the armor was gone. The cloth was gone. The metal was gone.

No rot left trapped beneath steel. No hidden poison waiting to enter the blood from a wound sealed around filth and iron.

Nathanos forced himself to move.

He took clean water and a fresh cloth, then began to wash the wound as gently as he could.

Raphael flinched at the first touch, a weak tremor passing through him, but he no longer had the strength to fight the pain. His eyes drifted half-closed, wet lashes trembling against his skin. His breathing came thin and uneven, but it came.

That was enough.

For now, that had to be enough.

Nathanos cleaned until the worst of the blood was gone. He wiped Raphael's chest, his side, the blood from his stomach where it had run in dark lines toward his waist. Then, at last, he reached up and eased the towel from Raphael's mouth.

Raphael's jaw slackened. No words came. Only a broken breath.

Nathanos brushed a damp strand of hair away from Raphael's face, careful even now, as if Raphael might break beneath anything less than gentleness.

"It's done," he said softly. "The armor is off. The wound is clean."

Raphael's eyes moved faintly toward him, but he could not answer.

"I know," Nathanos whispered. "Don't speak."

He lifted the glass again and brought it to Raphael's lips. This time Raphael did not try to help.

Nathanos supported his head with one hand and poured only a little water into his mouth, waiting for each painful swallow before giving him more.

"Slowly," he murmured. "You're safe now. I've got you. Everything will be alright."

Raphael swallowed once. Then again.

When he could take no more, Nathanos lowered the glass and set it aside. From the storage beneath the bench, he found the spare clothes folded for travel: a clean shirt, softer than armor had any right to be near. He dressed Raphael with careful hands, guiding the fabric over one arm, then the other, lifting him only as much as he had to.

Raphael remained limp through most of it, exhausted beyond pride, his body too drained to resist even the gentleness of Nathanos's hands.

When it was done, Nathanos reached for one of the folded blankets stored beneath the bench and wrapped it around Raphael's shoulders, tucking it close for warmth while keeping the fabric loose around the wound.

Only then did he sit back.

The ruined chest plate lay smoking faintly on the floor. The carrier smelled of blood, burned cloth, and candle wax.

Raphael breathed.

Nathanos watched him with shaking hands and told himself that, for this moment, breathing was victory.

For a while, that was all he could do.

Then the smell reached him again.

Burned cloth. Blood. Skin.

His gaze slipped to the ruined chest plate despite himself, to the torn fabric clinging to its inner side, to the dark pieces he refused to name. His throat tightened. His stomach turned.

Then he reached for another water flask.

His hand shook as he pulled the stopper free. He brought it to his mouth and drank, swallowing hard, again and again, until the flask was empty and the cold water hurt going down. It did not wash the smell away. It did not take the sight from his mind.

When the bottle was empty, it slipped from his fingers and struck the floorboards with a dull sound.

He did not pick it up.

Too much death had already come from the Night Stalker today. Too many men left behind in the snow. Too much blood. Too many faces Nathanos would have to remember when the silence finally found him.

But not Raphael.

The Night Stalker would not claim Raphael too. Nathanos had ensured it.

He leaned forward and reached beneath the blanket, finding Raphael's hand where it lay limp against his side. His fingers closed around it carefully at first, then tighter, as if holding him there could keep him from slipping any farther away.

"Raphael," he said quietly.

No answer.

Only breath.

That had to be enough.

Nathanos bent closer. "I'm going outside now. I'll drive the carrier from the front, but I will stop when I can and check on you. Again and again, if I have to."

Raphael's lashes trembled faintly.

"If you need me," Nathanos said softly, "you call for me. Scream if you must. I will hear you."

Raphael did not answer.

Nathanos's grip tightened around his hand.

“You are strong,” he whispered. “Stronger than anyone I know. So do not die on me. Not now. Not after this.”

His thumb pressed lightly over Raphael’s knuckles through the blanket.

“Promise me.”

Still, Raphael gave no words.

He only breathed, thin and broken beneath the candlelight.

Nathanos held on for one heartbeat longer, as if his hand alone could anchor him to the living.

Then he forced himself to let go.

Before he opened the door, his gaze fell again to the ruined chest plate.

No.

Raphael would not breathe that stench all the way to Kalluth. He would not wake, even half-conscious, and see what had been torn from him. Nathanos would not leave that reminder beside him like some cruel trophy of what saving him had cost.

He bent, grabbed the armor by one cooler edge, and lifted it with a grimace.

Then he opened the carrier door.

Cold wind struck him at once.

Nathanos stepped down into the snow and threw the chest plate as far as he could.

It vanished into the white with a dull, smoking thud.

For a moment, he stood there breathing the clean winter air, letting it cut through the horror trapped in his lungs. Then he looked back at the carrier.

Raphael was inside.

Alive.

For now.

Nathanos shut the door carefully, leaving the candles burning within, and turned toward the horses.

The two carrier horses waited where they had been bound, restless beneath frost and harness, stamping at the snow as if they too had heard enough pain for one night. Nathanos moved to them quickly, unfastening the ropes from the tree with fingers that still trembled despite his effort to steady them.

“Easy,” he murmured to the first.

The horse tossed its head, breath steaming in the darkening air.

“I know.”

He freed the second, then checked the harness lines with fast, practiced movements. As he worked, his eyes drifted beyond the carrier.

Other horses stood between the trees.

The mounts of the fallen.

They waited where their riders had left them, reins tied to low branches, saddles dusted with snow. Some shifted anxiously. Some stood too still.

Nathanos’s chest tightened.

He could not take them all. He could not bury the men who had ridden them. Not now.

But he would not leave the animals tied there to freeze, starve, or be found by whatever still moved through Velldenar after dark.

He stepped toward the nearest one and raised two fingers.

A thin line of golden flame slipped from his hand. The rope burned through in a quiet snap.

The horse startled back, then turned, uncertain.

“Go,” Nathanos said.

It did not understand the word, but it understood freedom. After a moment, it moved away through the snow.

Nathanos went to the next. Then the next.

One by one, he burned the ropes that held them. Small flames, controlled and brief, each one no brighter than a candle before the cord gave way.

The horses scattered slowly at first. Then faster.

Shapes of breath and muscle moved through the white, hooves striking snow, tails vanishing between the trees until the last of them broke into a gallop and disappeared into Velldenaar's darkening forest.

If the cold took them, it would not be because he had left them bound.

When the last rope fell blackened into the snow, Nathanos stood alone among the trees.

The wind moved through the branches. The bodies remained behind him. The hut remained behind him.

The mask at his belt seemed heavier than before.

Nathanos turned back to the carrier.

He climbed onto the driver's bench and took the reins in both hands. The leather felt cold against his palms. Real. Cruel. Necessary.

For a moment, he looked back toward the small window, where dim golden candlelight trembled behind frost-clouded glass.

"Stay with me, Raphael," he whispered.

Then he faced the road north.

The horses shifted beneath the harness.

Nathanos drew in one cold breath and snapped the reins gently.

The carrier began to move.

Snow broke beneath the wheels.

The forest slowly opened before them, pale and endless, leading toward Kalluth.

“We are going home.”